

could all do better in this World Cup, and all I said was that I wanted to be there till the end and finish the game.”

Jemimah claimed Harleen’s number three spot and made a fine case for why the position should be hers for the foreseeable future.

Eight games, three losses, and countless lessons later, India had found what was potentially its best eleven of the tournament. It was time now to go all the way.

A two-hour delay potentially ate into the anxious build-up for both India and South Africa. A maiden ICC crown awaited the winner of the contest. Laura Wolvaardt opted to chase.

Smriti and Shafali turned the clock back, but with an asterisk. The latter, as usual, played enforcer, but without the unnecessary risk-taking that had become associated with her. The pair blunted South Africa early on and put up a century stand. After losing Smriti, Shafali continued before falling 13 runs short of a famous ton. Deepti (58) and Richa (34), who was reportedly playing with far more serious damage to her finger than publicly known, carried India to 298. A steely Wolvaardt kept a boisterous 39,555-strong crowd quiet enough to hear a pin drop for large parts of the chase. An inspired decision by Harmanpreet saw Shafali being handed the ball.

With a lazy action and not much of an international record, she came

out of the syllabus in South Africa’s biggest test. The side didn’t know whether to play it safe or attack. Shafali’s first spell yielded two wickets and the big scalps of Sune Luus and Marizanne Kapp.

Wolvaardt’s partnership with Annerie Dercksen critically raised the collective blood pressure of all those present. While Renuka and Deepti were managing to bowl on the stumps to Wolvaardt, giving her no room for her vintage stroke play, errant lines helped Dercksen smash a few sixes. Deepti — who finished the night with a fifer — removed the Proteas captain and Tryon in the 42nd over to put India on top. De Klerk had pulled off a miracle before, but

that kind of lightning was not destined to strike the same adversary twice, with India sealing its maiden World title at the stroke of midnight, with Harmanpreet taking a very Kapil Dev-esque catch to finally wake the sleeping giant of world cricket. With the who’s who of Indian cricket — including Sachin Tendulkar, Rohit Sharma, Diana Edulji, and others — watching along nervously, Harmanpreet realised a dream 52 years in the making.

After an emotional embrace with Harmanpreet with the Indian flag enveloping both the senior pros, Smriti summed up India’s motivations: “The last T20

World Cup was a difficult one for us to take. We had a clear focus on working on our fitness, working on each and every aspect. The way everyone just stuck in and played — in a World Cup like this, everyone was there for each other.”

Historic triumphs can push post-mortems down the priority list, but this Indian team knows better than to not evaluate. It experimented till the end, with far too much risk involved in those punts not working.

This has undoubtedly been India’s most prolific tournament with the bat, with an average of 41 runs per wicket and a scoring rate of over six runs an over. That said, strike rotation, scoring rates, and fielding need serious work.

There is also the big leadership question facing the Indian setup. Is it time to hand Smriti, the vice-captain, the reins of the team? Can the most united Indian setup finally ace a power transfer? Can mental health support finally become a permanent part of India’s support cushion?

As world champion, efforts to polish how the women’s setup looks in India will bring all these questions and more. But for now, the party won’t stop, and rightly so. This Indian team is not the future of women’s cricket. It is the present, and it is just getting started!

Clutch player: Jemimah Rodrigues — once dropped, now indispensable — anchored India’s greatest chase with a masterclass in timing, temperament, and quiet defiance in the semifinal against Australia. GETTY IMAGES

